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Erie To Pittsburgh Trail Generates \$7 Million In Economic Activity Annually

A recent survey of trail users along the [Erie to Pittsburgh Trail](#) between Titusville and Parker by the Rails-to-Trails Conservancy showed a total economic impact of more than \$7 million annually in local communities.

Data was collected that shows 158,507 users visited the combined trails in 2013.

The economic impact comes from the amount of money trail users spend on food and lodging in the area. The average amount spent per user visit was \$21.62.

"When cyclists are traveling 20 miles or further they tend to either take some food with them or stop along the trail to purchase something," said Patricia Tomes, Program Manager for the RTC Northeast and project manager for the survey. "The more a town can inform the trail user of what services they have available, the more likely the trail user is to get off trail to participate. This works equally for attractions like the Drake Well Museum the convenience store in downtown Franklin, or the ice cream shop in Emlenton."

Uses of the trail ranged from biking to walking to fishing to geocaching.

The survey also collected data to determine where the trail users are coming from. They are residents from 25 different counties in Pennsylvania, New York and Ohio with the majority of users residing in Venango County, Butler County, Allegheny County, Clarion County and Crawford County. Another 10 percent travelled from 14 different states. Thirteen percent paid for overnight lodging in the area, with an average stay of 2.6 nights.

The new survey confirms a \$3 million increase in the annual economic impact between Titusville and Parker since 2006.

This survey and report is the eighth in a series of surveys that RTC has completed on trails in Pennsylvania. Every trail surveyed has demonstrated a positive economic impact from a low of \$8.35 per user visit to a high of \$33.50 per user visit. The results from this section of the Erie to Pittsburgh Trail are among the highest in the state and correlate to the tremendous popularity of the trail.

With assistance from the Council on Greenways and Trails and the [Allegheny Valley Trails Association](#), infra-red counters were located along the rail-trails that parallel Oil Creek and the Allegheny River. The counters detect passing heat signatures and provided an hour by hour count of activity on the trail 24/7.

A self-selecting paper survey was used in conjunction with the counters to solicit feedback from trail users throughout the valley. The survey was designed by Rails-to-Trails Conservancy specifically to collect and analyze data that reflects the economic impact of the trail users in local communities.

For more information or to see the entire report, contact Debra Frawley, Greenways Coordinator at 814-677-3152 Ext. 116 or send email to: dfrawley@oilregion.org, or visit the [Erie to Pittsburgh Trail](#) website.

(Reprinted from the [April 30 Resource](#) newsletter from DCNR.)

Posted by [David E. Hess](#) at [10:50 AM](#)

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